

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

CASE STUDY

RITIKA ANIL KUMAR | 28 |
Communications manager, Creatnet Education, Delhi

"I was called Blackie, African"

When Ritika speaks about the prejudice she endured due to her dark skin, her amused chuckle masks years of navigating societal biases that began in early childhood. During her formative years at a Christian school in Tiruvalla, Kerala, classmates taunted her with derogatory nicknames like "Blackie", "Black Beauty" and "African".

Even at the tender age of six, Ritika sensed something was "not right" about her skin tone, a perception reinforced by relatives who frequently compared her to her lighter-skinned brother. Well-intentioned but harmful "treatments" suggested by her grandmother further cemented the notion that her dark complexion was somehow undesirable.

The unwavering support from her physician parents helped Ritika develop resilience against colourist remarks. Her mother's wisdom—"your outside does not determine what is inside you"—became Ritika's emotional armour, making her thick-skinned to cope with the bias.

– Bandeep Singh

casting, ostracisation and bullying for being different," says psychologist Upasana Chaddha.

Biases that have only intensified in the past two decades, according to Parameswaran. Blame it on social media, whose algorithm-laden bubbles prioritise glossy images that exude perfection. Many a young, impressionistic mind thinks nothing of using a filter or an AI tool to project a picture of how they would wish to look rather than how they actually are. And no one has profited more from this insecurity than the beauty industry.

THE FAIRNESS BOOM

You may not call them fairness creams any more in these politically-correct times, but the 'skin lightening' business has not gone anywhere. It is expected to cross $2.4 billion (Rs 20,500 crore, at current exchange rates) by 2030, propelled primarily by urban and semi-urban areas, lured as they are by the spread of online beauty retail, an increased availability of brands and the massive social media buzz around skin health.

And it's not just women who are buying into the spiel, men are too. "I have been doing facials and blackhead removals for a few years now. I see nothing wrong with it," says 17-year-old Arjun Mehta (*name changed*) from a prominent Delhi school. A 2020 research paper in the journal *Open Linguistics* traced how television commercials at the turn of the 21st century